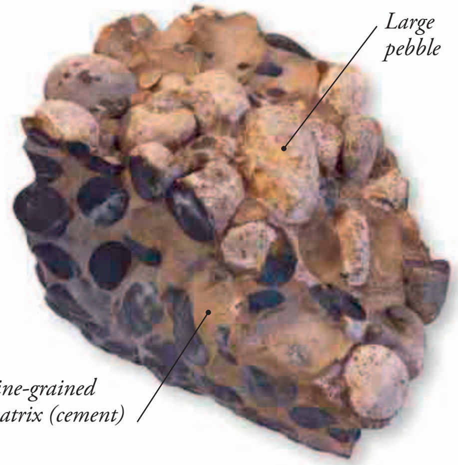
CLAY

The finest sediments of all are created from the chemically altered minerals of weathered rocks such as granite. They bind together to form clay, which always contains water. Clay can be molded and then "fired" in a potter's kiln to make rock-hard ceramics.

▼ PUDDING STONE
Conglomerates are sometimes called pudding stones because the big stones look like fruit in a pudding.



LIMESTONE

Some sedimentary rocks are formed by chemical processes. These include oolitic limestone, which is made up of tiny calcite balls. The balls settled out of warm seawater that was full of dissolved lime. Other limestones are built up from the chalky shells and skeletons of marine life such as plankton that lived and died in ancient oceans.

▼ WHITE CLIFFS
These chalk cliffs on the south coast of England are made from the remains of trillions of tiny organisms that lived more than 65 million years ago.

CONGLOMERATE AND BRECCIA

Sedimentary rocks are usually made of grains of very similar sizes, but conglomerates are made of big, water-rounded pebbles cemented together by much finer-grained material. Many conglomerates are the petrified remains of ancient beaches. A similar rock called breccia contains big stones with sharp edges. These were often transported by ice before being cemented together.

COAL

Waterlogged plant remains that do not decay can build up and turn into peat. If it is buried and compressed for millions of years, peat can turn into coal. Coal is almost pure carbon, which is why it can be burned as a fuel.